



EN PASSANT

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Today I watched a boy — and yes, I can call him that because he was not even born when I first won the world title in 2000 — win the World championship. D. Gukesh, just 18, is now the 18th World champion and if the future of chess had a face, it would probably look a lot like his — calm, sharp, and self-assured.

His win in the 14th round caught me by surprise — mostly because of its suddenness. I think everyone was expecting the final round to end in a draw. **The position was not yet lost, and then suddenly, Ding Liren blundered, and boom — the match was over.** It all unfolded unexpectedly, but Gukesh was rewarded for his perseverance, for his decision to keep trying and chess rewarded him for that.

Gukesh showed throughout the match that

he was willing to stick to his plan, try interesting ideas every day, and always look for a fight — even when faced with setbacks. He stayed true to his guns from start to finish, and I liked his approach. He pushed, pushed, and kept pushing, refusing to back down. Full credit goes to him and his entire team. I'm also very happy that we were able to support him through the Westbridge Anand Chess Academy. He took the plan forward, overcame challenges, and made it work.

Ding, too, proved himself to be a great champion. However, today, it felt like he somehow wanted the match to end. He appeared hasty to finish things, to exchange pieces quickly, and he got punished for that.

However, throughout the 14-game finale, Ding showed tremendous preparation and